Within the context of India, formal gardens have long been associated with royal rule. "Each royal garden was a metaphor for the formal symmetry of imperial rule imposed over the turbulent, multi-layered, social landscape of India. Just as the physical landscape was disciplined by the Emperor, so was society."[29] Beyond the Taj Mahal, Shah Jahan was said to have directed the construction of 999 pleasure gardens and it was in his reign that the Mughal Garden tradition reached its apex. All of these gardens were characterized by the traditional Islamic fascination with running water,[30] and even today a number of these and earlier works survive, such as Ram Bagh in Agra, Pinjore Gardens in Haryana, Shalamar Gardens in Lahore and Shalimar Bagh in Srinagar.

Shalamar Gardens, which was constructed on the orders of Shah Jahan between 1641-2, shows a number of similarities to the Taj gardens. It is a walled complex, has a rectilinear overall design, extensively uses flowing waters, and is constructed in a distinct series of terraces aligned south to north, much as the Taj is divided into sections[31]. However, unlike these gardens, the Taj could not be built at the base of a steep incline and thus tap into the natural power of water descending slopes in order to power its fountains and pools. Instead, the Taj uses an elaborate system of ingenious waterworks to achieve the same results[32].

Finally, visitors pass along the reflecting pool up the steps of another raised marble platform to the mausoleum itself. Behind the mausoleum, the land drops away toward the Yamuna River and more gardens, so it appears that there is nothing behind the Taj, which seems to stand alone on the horizon. Since the Taj is a perfectly symmetrical square (with one exception that is discussed below), visitors could approach from any direction, but it is made obvious by the gardens that the designers intended visitors to appreciate it from here.

The imposing facade is dominated by two elements: the soaring iwan gate and, above it, the white marble onion dome. Flanking the dome are two chhatris, below which are decorative balconies. Finally, at the outer edge of the four corners of the platform are the minaret-like spires. The entire structure is constructed in luminous white marble, though from this distance you can already make out hints of the elaborate decorative motifs that adorn the building.